

Heuristic Evaluation Report

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Part II: Project Description

Rome2rio is a multi-modal travel search engine that helps users find routes and compare transportation options (flights, trains, buses, ferries) between any two locations worldwide.

Part III: Evaluation Execution

I conducted this heuristic evaluation on the Rome2rio website (`rome2rio.com`) using a desktop web browser. The evaluation was performed by systematically testing three key user tasks while referring to Nielsen's 10 heuristics. The provided information on the website was sufficient to complete the evaluation without needing an account for most functions.

Tasks Performed:

- **Task 1:** Planning a Complex Multi-City Trip – Searching for a route from Bologna, Italy, to Lisbon, Portugal, with a stopover in Madrid, Spain.
- **Task 2:** Comparing Transportation Modes and Prices – Finding and comparing all available travel options (train, bus, flight, car) for a short trip from Paris to Brussels.
- **Task 3:** Accessing Booking Details – Selecting a specific train option from the search results and navigating to the external provider to complete the booking.

Part IV: List of Violations

- **Issue 1 – H1: Visibility of System Status**
 - **Where:** Search results page - when loading route information
 - **What:** When searching for routes between destinations, there is no clear loading indicator or progress feedback showing that the system is processing the request. Users are left uncertain whether the search is working or if they need to refresh.

- **Why:** The system does not keep users informed about what is happening through appropriate feedback within reasonable time.
- **Severity:** 3

- **Issue 2 – H3: User Control and Freedom**

- **Where:** Booking process - multiple redirects through partner websites
- **What:** When users attempt to book a ticket, they are redirected multiple times through different external partner websites. There is no clear way to return to Rome2Rio without losing search progress.
- **Why:** Excessive redirects remove user control and create a confusing journey.
- **Severity:** 3

- **Issue 3 – H4: Consistency and Standards**

- **Where:** Main navigation menu
- **What:** The website lacks a dedicated "Home" button. The logo is clickable, but not all users know this convention.
- **Why:** Users unfamiliar with this standard may struggle, reducing accessibility.
- **Severity:** 2

- **Issue 4 – H5: Error Prevention**

- **Where:** Search bar
- **What:** The search bar allows entering unsupported locations, only displaying "No results found" after pressing Enter.
- **Why:** Early suggestions should prevent invalid input.
- **Severity:** 2

Positive Usability Features

- **Strength 1 – H8: Aesthetic and Minimalist Design**

- **Where:** Overall website interface and layout
- **What:** The website features a clean, organized design with clear visual hierarchy, ample white space, and consistent color coding for different transport types (planes, trains, buses). Information is presented in an easy-to-scan format without clutter.
- **Why this works well:** The minimalist approach helps users quickly find relevant information without being overwhelmed. Consistent icons, colors, and layouts create a cohesive experience focused on the primary task: finding and comparing travel routes.

- **Impact:** Reduces cognitive load and supports efficient decision-making for all user levels.

- **Strength 2 – H1: Visibility of System Status**

- **Where:** Search results page - split-screen layout with route list and interactive map
- **What:** The interface displays a dual-panel view: the left side shows detailed trip information (departure times, connections, transfer points), while the right side shows an interactive map with the complete route visualization. The map updates to highlight segments as users interact with the trip details.
- **Why this works well:** Users stay constantly informed about both practical logistics and geographical context. They can see at a glance how segments connect and understand where transfers occur, which is especially valuable for multi-leg journeys.
- **Impact:** Reduces uncertainty and helps users make informed decisions by providing schedules and geographical context simultaneously.

Part V: Summary and Recommendations

Violations Summary

Heuristic	# Violations
H1: Visibility of system status	1
H2: Match between system and the real world	0
H3: User control and freedom	1
H4: Consistency and standards	1
H5: Error prevention	1
H6: Recognition rather than recall	0
H7: Flexibility and efficiency of use	0
H8: Aesthetic and minimalist design	0
H9: Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors	0
H10: Help and documentation	0
HN: Non-heuristic issue	0

General Impressions and Recommendations

Rome2rio is a powerful tool for finding complex travel routes, but its usability is hampered by an interface that can feel overwhelming and sometimes unresponsive. The core strength lies in its ability to aggregate diverse travel options, but presenting this information clearly is a challenge. The most significant trends noticed were a lack of clear feedback during system processing and an overly dense presentation of results that can lead to user fatigue and difficulty in making optimal choices.

Beyond the specific violations, Rome2rio could benefit from more advanced, user-controlled filters. For instance, allowing users to set a maximum budget, a maximum number of trans-

fers, or a preferred carbon footprint threshold would significantly enhance efficiency. Furthermore, implementing a "favorites" or "compare" feature would allow users to shortlist 2–3 options and view them side-by-side. Improving the visual hierarchy on the results page to better group options by primary mode of transport, with easy-to-expand sections, would greatly reduce cognitive load.